

SPECIAL RULE

The Rule of Collective Nouns & Question Tags

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The Rule of Collective Nouns

- Collective nouns (like jury, committee, team, or government) can take either a singular or plural verb and pronoun based on the context of the action.

1. Singular Usage:

- **Formal Unity**
- When the group acts unanimously or as a single unit, we use a singular verb (**has**), a singular possessive pronoun (**its**), and a singular question tag (**hasn't it?**).
- **Context:** The jury has reached a final, collective verdict.
- **Sentence:** The jury **has** taken **its** decision, **hasn't it?**

2. Plural Usage:

- Individual Action
- We use plural verbs and pronouns when the members of the group are acting individually, or when there is disagreement within the group.

Context: The members of the jury are still arguing or haven't reached a consensus.

Sentence: The jury **have** not yet reached an agreement, **have they**?

Examples

- The committee **is** ready, **isn't it**?
- The committee **are** arguing, **aren't they**?
- The jury **has** taken **its** decision, **hasn't it**?
- The jury (members) **have** taken **their** seats, **haven't they**?
- The audience **was** silent.
- The audience **were** clapping **their** hands, **weren't they**?

Examples

- The team **wins** every year, **doesn't it?**
- The team **are** wearing **their** new uniforms, **aren't they?**
- As a Unit: "The government **has** passed the bill, **hasn't it?**" (*Focus on the official act*).
- As Individuals: "The government **are** divided on the tax issue, **aren't they?**" (*Focus on the internal disagreement*).

Be Careful! The "Plural-Only" Collective Nouns

- Some nouns describe a group but **always take a plural verb**. They do not have a singular form in this context.
 - **Police:** It is always "The police **are** coming, **aren't they?**"
 - **Cattle:** "The cattle **are** grazing, **aren't they?**"
 - **Poultry/Vermin:** These also follow the plural-only rule.
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- **The Public** is almost always treated as a plural noun in formal grammar, especially when referring to their opinions or actions.
 - "The public **are** requested to remain seated, **aren't they?**"
 - "The public **have** a right to know, **don't they?**"

Be Careful! The "Staff" and "Faculty" Dilemma

- In British English, **staff** and **faculty** are often treated as **plural** (the individuals), whereas in American English, they are more commonly treated as a singular unit.
- British Preference: "The staff **are** unhappy with the new hours, **aren't they?**"
- American Preference: "The staff **is** meeting in the breakroom, **isn't it?**"

A "fail-safe" way to avoid confusion is to add the word **members**.

- Instead of:

The jury has/have taken its/their decision...

- Use:

The members of the jury have taken their decision, haven't they?